

In a future world, the authorities are trying to capture Indigenous Canadians. The narrator, Frenchie, and a group of other Indigenous people are hiding from them in the wilderness and cannot stay in the same place for long. One day Frenchie comes face to face with a moose.

I aimed the gun¹, watching the trees, praying² for nothing more than a deer³, nothing human, really.

It was huge, like a tree had yanked itself up and was slowly moving into the clearing, a tree with bone white branches.

It walked further into the grass. A moose. I'd never seen one this close before. Adrenaline made my teeth chatter.

Time is slow in that vacuum space. In this new space, I had time to aim squarely between the moose's eyes. Then I decided against it, lowering the barrel to his chest⁴: always go for the sure target. Miig had taught us that on one of my first hunts, and I listen to my Elders.

Just then he raised his head, so massive I wondered at the blood it must take to animate, and he saw me. He blinked⁵ a long, slow blink and faltered for only a second or two before he began chewing⁶ again. He turned a bit so that I knew he knew I was there. I swallowed hard, aiming, fingers exact and stiff. He was so big. It was like he was a hundred years old, like he had watched all of this happen. Imagine being here through it all — the wars, the sickness, the earthquakes, the schools — only to come to this?

He exhaled, long and loud like the wind. This was food for a week. This was me, the conquering hero, marching into camp with more meat than all of us could carry. This was Rose looking at me with those big eyes so dark they shone burgundy in the firelight. This was my chance.

But could we travel with this meat before it rotted⁷? No. And could we smoke and dry it? No, Miig wouldn't set up camp for that long, especially not with a steady thread of smoke reaching above the trees, blasting a signal to anyone who might be out there. So we'd be leaving half, at least half, behind to rot.

The moose watched all this play out on my face, a dirty boy tangled in the roots of an upended tree. And he stayed perfectly still. His eyes were huge, dark globes that reflected back their surroundings. I was sure I could see myself in there, in the trees, a long-haired warrior taking aim.

I lowered the rifle. He blinked once more, then crossed his legs, one over the other as if at the start of a curtsy then turned back into the trees.

I couldn't do it. I couldn't let it come to this, not for him and not for me.

Walking back to the meeting point, I swung between peace with my decision and wrenching regret. I was empty-handed, but something in my chest was burning a little brighter. I was okay with my decision, but not okay with the consequences. I secretly hoped no one else had gotten anything so I wouldn't be the only loser, even if it meant we went hungry for a day. I pictured RiRi's face, sad because of an empty belly. That made me ashamed.